

Unhoused Refugees in Ontario

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Introduction

Immigration is a big part of Canada's identity. That is why it is important to create policies that make settling into Canada safe and reliable. These policies also affect asylum seekers (people that come to Canada and make a refugee claim either at the airport or in land) which have been increasing in recent years. Between January and July 2023 alone, there have been 69,090 asylum claimants processed by the Canada Border Services Agency (CBSA) and the Ministry of Immigration, Refugees and Citizenship Canada (IRCC) agencies (Government of Canada, 2023). However, for many municipalities, there are simply not enough social programs to serve this influx. This process is greatly complicated by the unaffordable and insufficient supply of the housing market (CBC, 2023). The goal of this report is to examine what housing policies and programs exist for refugees, and the consequences of inadequate funding. Government Assisted Refugees (GAR) and Refugee Claimants (RC) in several Ontario municipalities will be examined. To explore this topic, news articles, government websites, and reports were searched in addition to conducting an interview with a caseworker at a local emergency shelter.

Government Assisted Refugees ("GAR")

In Ontario, GAR's receive government assistance upon arrival are given "landed immigrant" status. Families can receive an initial loan that is interest-free to cover the cost of transportation fees for a maximum of \$10,000 per family (Government of Canada, 2020). Additionally, they are eligible for "resettlement assistance" through the Resettlement Assistance Program (RAP) arranged by the federal government (Government of Ontario, 2022). An example of this program is in Hamilton, where the non-profit organization "Wesley" runs a RAP. Once registered in the program, individuals can receive an initial sum of money and subsequent monthly payments. Within the first four to six weeks of the RAP, various supports are provided in addition to temporary housing, either at the Wesley Reception Centre or a contracted hotel. Examples of support provided by RAP include familiarizing individuals with the city (e.g., public transit, education and health systems, local laws and customs), personal finance (budgeting and banking), basic personal skills (depending on individual client-needs), and referrals to other refugee programs. After that 6 weeks, financial assistance remains for up to 12 months, or otherwise ends when clients can support themselves (Government of Canada, 2023).

Upon entry to Canada, GAR's receive support to make the transition to permanent and stable accommodations less stressful and time consuming. It is

shown that this group experiences homelessness proportionally to Canadian-born citizens and other newcomers. The causes for homelessness within these populations are generally consistent, and include: poverty, trauma, breakdown in family relationship, substance use, and poorer mental health (Oudshoorn, 2018). However, it was found that low educational attainment, lack of official language proficiency, mental and physical health issues, and trauma can make GAR's more vulnerable (Sherrell, 2001). This finding may be outdated but still is important to consider when examining potential vulnerabilities to becoming unhoused. The RAP has changed over the years to address these issues. Overall, if provided with adequate support, these individuals and families can thrive and integrate into Canada with ease.

Refugee Claimants ("RC")/ Asylum Seekers

For RC's or asylum claimants, the process for immediate shelter can be complicated. There are many ways these individuals can access "interim housing", which is housing that is temporarily provided until permanent housing is secured. Examples of interim housing include government contracted hotels, emergency shelters (i.e., shelters for unhoused people), churches, and civilians that volunteer to host in their own home. Within Ontario, municipalities might each have unique complications to overcome, but recurring themes across cities include capacity and funding limits.

With increasing asylum claims since 2017, provinces and municipalities have called for more support to help manage this. Currently, both provinces and cities did not have enough shelter or funding to manage this increase. In response, the IRCC created the Interim Housing Assistance Program (IHAP) in 2019. This program is a grant that is given primarily to provinces, albeit sometimes municipalities, to assist with increasing available interim housing for asylum claimants (Government of Canada, 2020). Interim housing is the responsibility of provincial and municipal governments, so this program aims to limit the need for help from the federal government (Government of Canada, 2020). Currently, the program is extended until March 2024 (Government of Canada, 2023). Eligible costs under this grant include temporary accommodations, transportation, and indirect costs for running interim housing programs for asylum claimants (Government of Canada, 2020).

In February 2023, over 1400 asylum seekers went in-person to the Niagara Falls Social Assistance and Employment Opportunities (SAEO). The SAEO administers provincial financial assistance programs, emergency shelter, and

other supports (Niagara Region, 2023). The Niagara Region, like many other regions, experienced a spike in asylum seekers, mainly coming from Quebec due to their emergency shelter's exceeding capacity limits (Lori, 2023). To combat this, the IRCC has increased the number of contracts with hotels to provide more rooms for asylum claimants. Additionally, rent deposits are given to individuals in IRCC hotels to help them get permanent housing. Since there are limited housing options available in this region, the length of stay has increased in these hotels. To keep up with this demand, requests by the Niagara region are made to both provincial and federal governments to receive more funding (Lori, 2023).

Emergency shelters are at capacity in Toronto as well, which prompts churches and nonprofits to step in. Since churches and nonprofits are paying out of pocket, they will not be able to continue if more funding is not received (CBC 2023). Toronto's city council passed a motion asking the federal government to reimburse these organizations with \$750,000 by September 18th 2023 . However, the federal government failed to do so, thereby forcing the city and community organizations to do it themselves (Balintec, 2023).

In Hamilton, there is an organization called International Association for Refugees Canada (IAFR) that runs a program called Open Homes. This is a multi-church network that connects new RC's with community members involved in the church network who volunteer as hosts. Hosts offer a space in their own homes for a period of 2 to 4 months. Subsequently, refugees are connected with the Open Homes leadership team, giving them access to community resources to help with the first steps in the refugee process (IAFR Canada). The IAFR also provides training to equip people with knowledge on how to provide support to displaced people. IAFR also runs other programs in other municipalities and globally (IAFR Canada).

Discussion with a caseworker at an emergency shelter in Hamilton

Between GAR's and RC's/ asylum seekers the processes are the same if they are unhoused and if GAR's are no longer eligible for the RAP. They are allowed to access emergency shelters just as any other unhoused person would. If they are not a GAR or did not make a refugee claim at the airport, they need to get a legal aid certificate. Then they can get a lawyer to fill out the Basis of Claim Form. Oftentimes these people need help with interpreting the meaning of the form, so a lawyer knows exactly what to put to give them a better chance of getting the claim approved. Usually at the same time a work permit is filled out,

if not it can still be done later. After the claim is made they get an Acknowledgement of Claim (AOC). This also gives them coverage under the Interim Federal Health Program (IFHP) giving access to some health care.

Work permits take months to get approved and to get housing, an income is needed. Once an AOC is obtained and a medical exam is completed, they are eligible for Ontario Works (OW), which provides financial assistance to people that require it. OW gives \$343 if using an emergency shelter and \$733 if housed. Housing can be acquired but it might take time to find due to the increasing cost of rent and lack of supply. Since housing is expensive there is the option to apply for subsidized housing. Subsidized housing is rent that is geared towards your income. However, the waiting list in some parts of Ontario exceeds 10 years, making it mostly unattainable for refugees (Vallis, 2023).

Overall, this process can be lengthy, increasing the need to use emergency shelters. Some asylum claimants have trouble completing this process alone and require assistance. Caseworkers can help these newcomers understand the process of settling in Canada and connect them to many resources within the city. In Hamilton, for people to get access to a caseworker, they have to be booked into a bed. If an asylum seeker cannot secure a bed due to the shelter being full, they do not have access to a caseworker. If more funding were available, it could increase the number of beds and workers to support them - preventing people from falling through the cracks.

Implications

There should be attainable housing for all as it is fundamental to one's well-being. The federal government agrees - as stated in the National Housing Strategy Act (Government of Canada, 2019). Housing should not be treated as an investment and is a human right. The fact that refugees have to resort to using emergency shelters and the streets says otherwise. These shelters are not viable solutions for them and there is inadequate space. It may take months to get housing because of insufficient OW income or wait times to get a work permit. If asylum seekers are not given guidance it makes the process of integration difficult. There may be other issues related to mental or physical health, trauma, low literacy rates, and low educational attainment and being unhoused only amplifies them. The path to being housed is difficult for asylum seekers and should be simplified for the sake of their well-being. If asylum seekers are given the opportunity by the government to get their claim approved, they should be

accommodated accordingly. If not, why keep them waiting on the streets only to reject them back to their home country?

Since the federal government wanted to increase the number of immigrants they should also be responsible for their well-being. When immigrants come here and do not have positive experiences early on they are likely to leave - onward migration is most prevalent within the first 10 years of arrival, 4 to 7 years being the greatest spike (Dennler, 2023). From 2017 to 2019 there was an increase of 31% greater than the historical average of immigrants leaving (Dennler, 2023). Additionally, since the 90's, the percentage of immigrants leaving has increased steadily (DeLaire, 2023). Some studies show that sense of belonging, homeownership, individual and family preferences, and immigration and economic opportunities in other countries are factors of onward migration but more studies are needed (Dennler, 2023). The housing crisis in Canada is impacting refugees greatly (DeLaire, 2023). In order to prevent this, more work needs to be done to monitor and investigate the reasons and factors for onward migration. More investments are needed for settlement services and infrastructure so people can have a more enjoyable life here early on (Dennler, 2023).

Canada's reliance on immigration should not be brushed aside. It has been shown that immigration helps the economy grow, support a good worker-to-retirees ratio, and ease shortages in labour which impact inflation. The longer immigrants stay the more they benefit our society and their own livelihoods (Dennler, 2023). The problem is that this issue has been overlooked. There is little data on immigration retention and onward migration is not in any administrative data (Dennler, 2023). The government has to be able to address these issues to keep immigrants healthy and staying within Canada. If the data and research is not there, it is hard for policy makers to take the best steps to improve early on experiences (Dennler, 2023). Homelessness should be further assessed as a possible factor of onward migration.

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